

the time was corrected to 10.09. The 10-second barrier remains the gold standard in sprinting, and at long last, the Indian record sat within touching distance of it.

Even that number carried special significance. As he crossed the finish line, Gurindervir tore off his chest bib and flung it onto the track. He screamed in exhilaration. He pulled off his sprint cleats and hurled them onto the track, then picked them up and kissed them. He hugged his coach, James Hillier, from the Reliance Foundation. He held up the reverse side of his bib, on which he had both predicted how he would run and laid out his bet for the future. "10.10 seconds. Task is not finished yet, wait. I am still standing," he had written on it.

This was his moment to thumb his nose at his naysayers, and Gurindervir, who has had his share of them, made the most of it. "When I started running, there were people who told me not to waste my time. They said that Indians don't make good sprinters. But I want to tell them they are wrong. Indian genes *tagde hain* (are strong)," he said.

Gurindervir wouldn't be the only one to have called his shot. The excitement had barely begun to settle when it was the turn of Tamil Nadu's TK Vishal to make the night his own. The 22-year-old was already the national record holder in the 400m event, having clocked 45.12 last year.

"Let's get the 44"

Gurindervir had insisted on running the sprints when advised to shift to the quarter-mile. Vishal, on the other hand, had been a promising sprinter who had only been guided to the 400m a couple of years back. Despite the late switch, he had been tipped to do far greater things. Right at the top of that bucket list was running a sub-45-second 400m.

In terms of track and field scoring standards, about as many people have run a sub-45-second 400m as have run a 10.06-second 100m. It's one of the benchmarks for excellence in the event. On Saturday morning, Vishal's coach, Jason



Memorable feat: In Ranchi, Vishal TK, 23, crossed the 400m finish line in 44.98 seconds — the first Indian in history to go below 45.

